

Trained to Tell the Difference

A 10-minute address to Christian men on Religion, Worship, Sacrifice, and the Obedience of Faith. The altar Christians still approach, and the Berean practice that trains a man to discern the Good.

Scripture from the NET Bible.

PART ONE: THE OUTLINE

Structure at-a-glance:

Segment	Time	Content
Open	0:00–1:30	The interrupted lesson (Heb 5:10–12)
The four layers	1:30–3:45	Religion, Worship, Sacrifice, Obedience of Faith
The discernment problem	3:45–5:15	Worship failures are perception failures
The altar today	5:15–7:15	Rom 12:1–2; covenant continuity; you are the priest and the offering; the cost question
The training	7:15–8:45	Berean practice as mind-renewal
Close	8:45–10:00	The stack completed in Christ (Heb 10)

The logical chain:

1. The solid food the Hebrews couldn't digest was the theology of sacrifice (Heb 5:10–11).
2. Scripture's four layers: Religion (form), Worship (disposition), Sacrifice (cost), Obedience of Faith (settled pattern).
3. The great worship failures are perception failures, men at layer 1 or 3 sincerely believing they're at layer 4. An untrained perception cannot audit itself.
4. Christians still sacrifice. The substitute is finished, so the symbol gives way to the reality: you are now both priest and offering (Rom 12:1; 1 Pet 2:5; Heb 13:15–16). The old standard still applies, the best, not the blemished, so the question becomes: am I offering my most costly possession, or the leftovers? (2 Sam 24:24; Mal 1:8).
5. Romans 12:2: the renewed mind is how the living sacrifice discerns the Good. Training the mind in the Word is not preparation for the sacrifice — it is part of the sacrifice.
6. The Berean habit (Acts 17:11) is the training regimen: daily, eager, examining.
7. Christ completed the whole stack first (Heb 10:5–10). Response, not payment.

Anchor texts (NET)

- Hebrews 5:10–14 ...the interrupted sacrifice lesson; perceptions trained by practice
- Romans 12:1–2 ..."present your bodies as a sacrifice, alive, holy, and pleasing to God, which is your reasonable service"; "be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may test and approve what is the will of God, what is good and well-pleasing and perfect"
- 1 Peter 2:5 ...a holy priesthood offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ
- Hebrews 13:15–16 ...the sacrifice of praise; doing good and sharing, "for God is pleased with such sacrifices"
- 2 Samuel 24:24 ..."I will not offer to the LORD my God burnt sacrifices that cost me nothing"
- Malachi 1:7–8, 14 ...the blemished offering; "How have we offended you?"
- 1 Samuel 15:22–23 ...obedience better than sacrifice
- James 1:26–27; John 4:23–24; Genesis 22:2; Hebrews 11:17–19; Romans 1:5; Acts 17:11; Hebrews 10:5–10

PART TWO: SPEAKER TEXT

OPEN — The interrupted lesson

For me, and perhaps for many Christian men, one of the most uncomfortable sentences in the New Testament could be Hebrews five, verse twelve:

"For though you should in fact be teachers by this time, you need someone to teach you the beginning elements of God's utterances."

By this time. The writer is doing math on them (years in the faith against what they can digest) and the numbers don't work.

But look at what he was teaching **when he stopped to say that**. Verse ten: Christ, a high priest in the order of Melchizedek. Verse eleven: about this we have much to say, and it's hard to explain, **because you've become sluggish in hearing**.

The lesson he broke off, *the solid food they couldn't chew*, was **the meaning of priesthood and sacrifice**. That's the meat in this letter.

So, that's the meal today... We present to you, four words, one question, and a training plan.

THE FOUR LAYERS

Scripture uses four words we often blur together. Stack them.

Layer one: Religion. James's word (1:26-27) (*threskeia*) the outward system.

Observance, attendance, identity. James says a man can have all of it, deceive his own heart, and his religion is **futile** (James 1:26). **Religion is the *form***. Alone, it proves nothing.

Layer two: Worship. The **disposition under the form**, the heart actually aimed at God, "in spirit and truth" (John 4:23–24). But a disposition is **invisible**, even to its owner. Sincere feeling that never lands is just sentiment.

Layer three: Sacrifice. Where the invisible becomes visible. **Sacrifice is worship's currency, the moment the disposition costs something and you pay it.** God didn't ask Abraham how devoted he felt. He said: "Take your son, your only son, whom you love" (Genesis 22:2). Hebrews says Abraham's faith became *visible* at the raised knife. You find out what a man worships by what he'll pay. So does he.

Layer four: The Obedience of Faith. Paul's phrase, it opens and closes Romans (1:5; 16:26). The whole stack aligned and *settled*. Not one dramatic act, *a life reorganized around what it claims*.

The sobering part: **each layer can exist without the ones above it.** Religion without worship, the Pharisee. Worship without sacrifice, sentiment. Sacrifice without obedience, that's Saul. Real animals, real altar. And Samuel's verdict: "**obedience is better than sacrifice**" (1 Samuel 15:22). Saul had layer three and thought it was layer four.

THE DISCERNMENT PROBLEM

And that's the connection back to Hebrews. Look at what these failures have in common.

Malachi's priests offer blind and lame animals, and when God confronts them, they answer (and I think they mean it) "**How have we offended you?**" (Malachi 1:7). They can't see it.

Saul comes home declaring, "I have done what the Lord said." He appears to **believe** it. Uzzah, with David rescuing the Ark of the Covenant from the Philistines, reached to

steady the Ark from falling. Uzzah's whole generation put the Ark on a cart instead of carrying it via poles, and nobody in a procession of thirty thousand perceived the problem.

These are not mainly failures of willpower. **They are failures of perception.** Men standing at layer one or three, sincerely certain they stood at layer four. And here's what should keep us up at night: *an untrained perception can't tell the layers apart, and it can't audit itself.* The infant doesn't know he's an infant. That's what infancy is.

Now hear Hebrews 5:14: **"Solid food is for the mature, whose perceptions are trained by practice to discern both good and evil."** Discernment isn't mainly spotting scandal. Saul's problem wasn't scandal; it was religion *wearing the costume of obedience. Discernment is telling form from disposition from cost from settled obedience.* Telling the Good (God's own character) from everything that merely resembles it.

THE ALTAR TODAY

Now the question this whole framework raises. **Do Christians offer sacrifices?**

Most of us would instinctively say no, that ended at the cross. And half of that instinct is exactly right. Hebrews ten says we have been made holy through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ **once for all.** The *atonement* sacrifice is finished. No altar you build adds anything to it. Never let anyone put you back under that.

But listen to what Paul does with the sacrificial language after saying all that. Romans twelve, verse one:

"Therefore, I exhort you, brothers and sisters, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a sacrifice, alive, holy, and pleasing to God, which is your reasonable service."

Sacrifice didn't end. **It changed material.** Under the old covenant, a substitute died in your place, you brought the lamb, and the lamb went on the altar instead of you. Now the Substitute has died, once for all. So, what goes on the altar? **You do. Alive.** The symbol has given way to the thing it always pointed to. *Peter says it outright: you are "a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ" (1 Peter 2:5).* Hebrews thirteen names them, praise on your lips, good done, possessions shared: "God is pleased with such sacrifices."

Now feel the weight of that priesthood upon you today. Malachi was written **to priests**, about the quality of their offerings. Peter just made *you* the priest. **Which means Malachi's question arrives at your door with no middleman.** God asked those priests: you bring the blind and lame, "offer it to your governor! Will he be pleased with you?" (Malachi 1:8). Would you hand your employer, your commanding officer, the quality of attention you hand God?

And the old standard came across the covenants untouched: **the best. The whole. The unblemished.** David understood it before the temple was even built: "I will not offer to the LORD my God burnt sacrifices that **cost me nothing**" (2 Samuel 24:24).

So here is the question. The offering is now *yourself*, body and mind. **Are you offering your best and most costly possession, or the leftovers?** The last eight minutes of the day, half-asleep, phone drained, lacking a thirst for the Word, brothers, that's the blemished lamb. Just made of minutes instead of wool.

And notice... Paul said *bodies* and then verse two: **"be transformed by the renewing of your mind."** Body *and* mind. The living sacrifice has two parts, and the second one is where this whole message lands.

THE TRAINING

Because look at why Paul says the mind gets renewed:

"...so that you may test and approve what is the will of God, what is good and well-pleasing and perfect" (Romans 12:2).

Do you hear it? The renewed mind exists **to discern the Good**. That is Hebrews 5:14 in Paul's handwriting. The living sacrifice and the trained perception are not two subjects, **they're verses one and two of the same paragraph**. *Renewing your mind in the Word isn't preparation for your sacrifice. It is your sacrifice, the daily portion of it.*

And the training method is the Berean one. Acts seventeen: they **eagerly received the message, examining the scriptures carefully every day to see if these things were so**. Both halves. Eager, they wanted it true. Examining (they checked an *apostle*), daily, and Luke calls them **noble** for it.

Think about what that daily man is actually doing. He's watching God draw the line between accepted and rejected worship (Cain and Abel, Nadab, Saul, Uzzah, Malachi, Ananias) hundreds of repetitions of the same lesson, until his perception is calibrated. Reps, like any trade. The tradesman's eye spots the crooked joint without a tape measure. **A man who has watched God draw that line a thousand times in Scripture starts seeing it in the room**, in the teaching he's weighing. Something he sees flags the blemished lamb before he can say why.

The man who isn't in the Book daily isn't just missing information. **He's missing the training data**. His sincerity is real, and uncalibrated. He will build new carts his whole life and never feel the wheels wobble, all the while thinking that he is serving the Good.

CLOSE: The stack, completed

Now the good news, from the same letter that rebuked the Hebrew Christians.

The writer finishes the lesson they were too dull to hear, and it lands at chapter ten, Psalm forty in the mouth of Christ: "**Sacrifice and offering you did not desire, but a body you prepared for me... I have come to do your will, O God.**"

Look at the stack in that sentence. **Perfect form. Perfect heart. The full cost**, a *body*, prepared and given, nothing kept back. And the settled, finished obedience: *I have come to do your will. Religion, worship, sacrifice, and the obedience of faith, aligned once, completely, in Him.* And by that will, we have been made holy, once for all.

He completed the stack before He asked you to climb it. He offered the costly sacrifice so that yours could be a **thank offering** instead of a payment. That's why Romans twelve begins "*by the mercies of God.*" Mercy first. Altar second.

So, priests of the Most High God, here's your training for tomorrow morning. One chapter. Before the phone. Your first minutes, not your last, **the unblemished ones**. Eager, and examining. *Lay your mind on the altar and let God train your eyes.*

The Apostle instructs... by this time, you ought to be teachers.

Offer your sacrifice with the Obedience of Faith.